

UNOFFICIAL FAN GUIDE

2026 SEASON GUIDE

Weekend Schedules, Qualifying & Points

A Beginner's Guide to the Formula 1 Season

Standard Race Weekend

A standard Formula 1 weekend spans three days (Friday to Sunday) and follows a consistent format of practice, qualifying, and race.

3

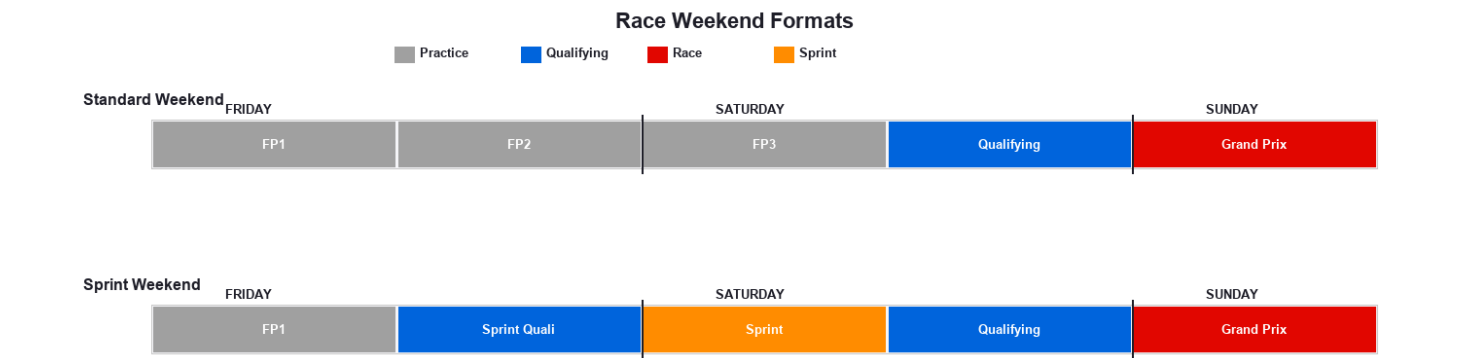
Days

5

Sessions

305

Race km



Standard vs Sprint weekend session schedules

Friday

Session	Duration	Purpose
Free Practice 1 (FP1)	60 minutes	Initial setup, tire evaluation, system checks
Free Practice 2 (FP2)	60 minutes	Long runs, race simulations, fine-tuning

FP1 often features rookie or reserve driver outings, as teams are required to run a young driver in at least two FP1 sessions per season.

Saturday

Session	Duration	Purpose
Free Practice 3 (FP3)	60 minutes	Final setup, qualifying preparation
Qualifying	~60 minutes	Determines grid positions (Q1/Q2/Q3 format)

Sunday

Session	Details
Drivers' Parade	Pre-race fan engagement (track tour)
Formation Lap	Grid forms, warm-up lap to grid positions
Grand Prix Race	Full race distance (typically 305 km / ~57-70 laps)
Podium Ceremony	Top 3 celebration, trophies, national anthems

Sprint Race Weekend

Six weekends in 2026 use the Sprint format. This compressed schedule replaces FP2 and FP3 with Sprint Qualifying and a short Sprint Race, adding an extra competitive session on Saturday.

Friday

Session	Duration	Purpose
Free Practice 1 (FP1)	60 minutes	Only practice session of the weekend
Sprint Qualifying (SQ)	~36 minutes	SQ1/SQ2/SQ3 to set Sprint grid

Saturday

Session	Duration	Purpose
Sprint Race	~30 min (100 km)	Short race, separate points awarded
Qualifying	~60 minutes	Sets grid for Sunday's Grand Prix

Sunday

Sunday is identical to a standard weekend: formation lap, Grand Prix, and podium ceremony.

Sprint Weekend Note

Parc ferme conditions apply from the start of Sprint Qualifying. Teams must balance setup for both the Sprint and the Grand Prix with very limited practice data from just one FP session.

Qualifying Format (Q1 / Q2 / Q3)

Qualifying uses a three-part knockout format to determine the starting grid for the Grand Prix.

Phase	Duration	Drivers	Eliminated	Grid Positions Set
Q1	18 minutes	All 22	Slowest 6	P17 - P22
Q2	15 minutes	Remaining 16	Slowest 6	P11 - P16
Q3	12 minutes	Top 10	None (ranked)	P1 - P10

With 22 drivers (11 teams), Q1 eliminates the bottom 6, Q2 the next 6, and Q3 determines the top 10 positions. The fastest driver in Q3 earns pole position.

107% Rule

Any driver who fails to set a Q1 time within 107% of the fastest Q1 lap may not be permitted to start the race, at the stewards' discretion.

Sprint Qualifying (SQ1 / SQ2 / SQ3)

Sprint Qualifying mirrors the main qualifying format but with shorter sessions:

Phase	Duration	Eliminated
SQ1	12 minutes	Slowest 6
SQ2	10 minutes	Slowest 6
SQ3	8 minutes	None (top 10 ranked)

Race Day Procedures

Pre-Race

- Pit lane opens 30 minutes before race start
- Cars take positions on the grid
- All cars must be on the grid 10 minutes before the start
- Tire blankets removed, teams clear the grid

Race Start

- Formation lap: Cars follow the pole-sitter around the circuit to warm tires and brakes
- Cars return to grid positions for a standing start
- Five red lights illuminate sequentially, then all extinguish simultaneously to signal the start
- Jump start penalties are detected automatically via sensors

Lights Out! - The Iconic F1 Start

The race start is one of F1's most thrilling moments. Five red lights come on one by one (about 1 second apart), then all go out at once. Drivers must react instantly - the best reaction times are under 0.2 seconds. A jump start (moving before lights out) results in a penalty.

During the Race

- Pit stops: Mandatory - at least one stop required, as drivers must use at least two different dry tire compounds during a dry race
- Active aero (X-mode) is available on designated straights, replacing the old DRS system
- Blue flags: Lapped cars must let leaders through within 3 flag points
- Track limits: Exceeding track boundaries leads to lap time deletion or time penalties

Race End & Classification

- Checkered flag shown to race leader after completing full race distance
- All cars must cross the finish line to be classified
- Race must complete at least 75% distance (2 laps behind safety car) for full points to be awarded
- If less than 75%, reduced points are awarded
- Post-race parc ferme and technical inspections follow

Points System

Grand Prix Points (Top 10)

Pos	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	6th	7th	8th	9th	10th
Pts	25	18	15	12	10	8	6	4	2	1

Points are awarded to the top 10 finishers only. There is no bonus point for fastest lap (abolished from 2025 onwards).

Sprint Points (Top 8)

Pos	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	6th	7th	8th
Pts	8	7	6	5	4	3	2	1

No fastest lap point is awarded in Sprint races. Sprint results count toward both the Drivers' and Constructors' Championships.

Maximum Points Per Weekend

Standard weekend: 25 pts (race win). Sprint weekend: 33 pts (8 Sprint win + 25 race win).

25

Max Pts (Standard)

33

Max Pts (Sprint)

25

Race Win

8

Sprint Win